to the question of *how* unknown and patently non-elite groups attained kingship during this historical moment.[26]

Perso-Islamic prestige cultures should be understood as lexicons for rule, or collective "playbooks," which, when mastered and enacted, were tantamount to actuations of kingship in central–western Eurasia. It was this vast complex of elite cultures that effectively allowed populations far-removed from cultural capitals both in distance and lifestyles – especially nomadic and/or transhumant groups – to become power-brokers and even rulers. A group of unknown Ghuris exemplified such a process, eventually emerging as politico-military elites styling themselves as Shansabanis. Their emergence and other, similar developments throughout the Persianate world underscore – counterintuitively – the essentially *egalitarian* nature of Perso-Islamic court culture: a recognizable language or code of behavior that could enable kingship for pretty much anyone with the acumen to master it, and the resources to implement it.

What, then, were the aspects of twelfth-century Perso-Islamic cultures of power, or lexicons for rule, that up-and-coming groups could command in order to actuate kingship? Rather than static constituent elements or "ingredients" comprising these lexicons, it is more fruitful to conceive of three, overlapping and even fungible spheres of activity, with appreciably wide ranges of possible expressions: one sphere was Islamic confessionalism; a second, the large-scale patronage of cultural production in both *intellectual* as well as *material* forms; and third – though by no means least important – was mobility. It might seem unnecessary to point out that the last two spheres of activity were not peculiar to Perso-Islamic kingship, but they deserve emphasis as they were reiterative of Islamic confessionalism, and were arguably fundamental to the ascendancy of the principal powers of the twelfth-century Persianate world. All three of these overlapping spheres of activity left historical traces in the landscapes the Shansabanis inherited, thus providing them with aspirational models for attaining kingship. The rising Shansabanis came to act within these three spheres – elucidated further below – in tandem with accruing regional and then transregional economic, political, and military primacy.

Further, rather than conceiving of Perso-Islamic kingship as unbounded and infinitely reproducible, positing its approximate *geographical* extent is useful as a counterpoint. The Qarakhitay (*c.* 1125–1218 CE), a nomadic power who occupied the Balasaghun region (modern Kyrgyzstan) as of the 1130s CE, seemed to personify the eastern borders of Perso-Islamic kingship's currency. Although being in intimate contact with their vassals the Qarakhanids (*c.* 998–1213 CE) and other subordinate powers such as the Khwarazm-shahs (*c.* 995–1231 CE) – who espoused Perso-Islamic kingly affiliations – these polities' Qarakhitay overlords emphatically did not. Rather than converting to Islam, the Khitay rulers retained Buddhist–animist and Christian affiliations, creating a composite kingly culture of